Books espousing such soft views were banned, as well as books that contradicted the official Qin version of history.

When one scholar argued that Qin Shi Huang should emulate the founder of the ancient Zhou dynasty and decentralise state power, the Qin chief minister, Li Si, countered that scholars should stop criticising present-day institutions by idealising the past. The regime ordered the confiscation of all books that romanticised antiquity or otherwise criticised the Qin. Such problematic texts were stored in the imperial library and could be studied only by official scholars.[69]

The Qin Empire was probably the most ambitious totalitarian experiment in human history prior to the modern age, and its scale and intensity would prove to be its ruin. The attempt to regiment tens of millions of people along military lines, and to monopolise all resources for military purposes, led to severe economic problems, wastefulness and popular resentment. The regime's draconian laws, along with its hostility to regional elites and its voracious appetite for taxes and recruits, fanned the flames of this resentment even further. Meanwhile, the limited resources of an ancient agrarian society couldn't support all the bureaucrats and soldiers that the Qin needed to contain this resentment, and the low efficiency of their information technology made it impossible to control every town and village from distant Xiangyang. Not surprisingly, in 209 BCE a series of revolts broke out, led by regional elites, disgruntled commoners and even some of the empire's own newly minted officials.

According to one account, the first serious revolt started when a group of conscripted peasants sent to work in a frontier zone were delayed by rain and flooding. They feared they would be executed for this dereliction of duty, and felt they had nothing to lose. They were quickly joined by numerous other rebels. Just fifteen years after reaching the apogee of power, the Qin Empire collapsed under the weight of its totalitarian ambitions, splintering into eighteen kingdoms.

After several years of war, a new dynasty – the Han – reunited the empire. But the Han then adopted a more realistic, less draconian attitude. Han emperors were certainly autocratic, but they were not totalitarian. They did not recognise any limits on their authority, but they did not try to micromanage everyone's lives. Instead of following Legalist ideas of surveillance and control, the Han turned to Confucian ideas of encouraging people to act loyally and responsibly out of inner moral convictions. Like